Machu Picchu

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Machu Picchu is a fifteenth-century Inca archaeological site in the Andes Mountains of Peru. It is known for its carefully constructed stone buildings, agricultural terraces, and dramatic mountain setting.

Location

Machu Picchu is located in southern Peru above the Urubamba Valley. The site lies in a mountainous environment between the Andes and the tropical region of the upper Amazon basin.

Inca Civilization

The site was constructed during the period of the Inca Empire. It is generally associated with the reign of the Inca ruler Pachacuti, who ruled during the fifteenth century.

Purpose

The exact original purpose of Machu Picchu is not known with complete certainty. Archaeologists have proposed several interpretations, including a royal estate, ceremonial center, or elite retreat.

Architecture

Inca builders are known for precisely fitted stonework. At Machu Picchu, many stones were shaped and placed without traditional mortar between major blocks.

Terraces

Agricultural terraces cover parts of the mountain slopes. These terraces helped create usable land and manage water and soil in steep terrain.

Water Management

The site contains channels, fountains, and drainage systems. Engineering was important because the location receives significant rainfall and is exposed to steep slopes.

Important Structures

Notable features include the Temple of the Sun, the Intihuatana stone, the Sacred Rock, and residential and agricultural areas.

European Contact

Machu Picchu was not destroyed by Spanish conquistadors and was largely unknown to the outside world during the Spanish conquest. The site became widely known internationally after Hiram Bingham's 1911 expedition, although local people already knew of the ruins.

Modern Significance

Machu Picchu is a UNESCO World Heritage Site and became one of the New Seven Wonders of the World in 2007.

Key Retrieval Terms

Peru, Andes, Inca Empire, Pachacuti, Urubamba Valley, stonework, terraces, Temple of the Sun, Intihuatana, water management.